He said he would ‘go out and fight independently for the idea of the Congress’.[22] This battle between the ‘secular’ Nehru and the ‘Hindu traditionalist’ Tandon, who termed it a ‘fight to decide whether Congress will live or die’,[23] led to a year-long internal power struggle for the control of the party structure, primarily on the ‘Hindu’ issues raised by Mookerjee. Nehru’s victory was not certain, and for a while, there was a distinct possibility of either a split within the party or the Congress, without Nehru as the helm, taking a turn rightwards.[24] It culminated in Nehru’s resignation from the Congress Working Committee on 9 August 1951[25] and a final show of strength that Nehru won, becoming party president in addition to prime minister. Tandon resigned. Chapter 9 of this book shows that the alternative ideas of the Hindu nationalists were not represented only by them—they enjoyed deep sympathies within the Congress leadership and were fought for as much within the party as outside.

Modi is both the outcome and harbinger of these ideas.

For one, like Nehru, he is uncompromising and unambiguous about his party’s ideology and ideals. As he emphasised in a victory speech after his second national election win in 2019, his party’s journey from ‘do se dobara (from two to once again)’ stood out because ‘we never stepped back from our path, never let our ideals dim. We never stopped, nor got tired, nor did we bend … We will never leave our ideals, nor our sanskaar.’[26] This stout defence of ideas is not that different from Nehru’s stringent insistence in the 1952 election campaign on what he called ‘an all-out war on communalism’, against ‘sinister communal elements’ that would ‘bring ruin and death to the country’.[27]

Second, Modi is unambiguous on the secularism question and what his party sees as its cynical manipulation. ‘For thirty continuous years especially,’ he has argued emphatically, ‘it was such a printout, such a tag that had become so fashionable. That whatever you do, you put it on. It was like doing a Ganga bath to get good credit [punya]. The name of this tag—and it was totally fake—was secularism.’ As he later told his National Democratic Alliance (NDA) partners, minorities were made to live in fear because of vote-bank